



changed and he doesn't consult them anymore. In the Rahman case, Basu had clearly stated that the government would remove the guilty officers. Only, the removal—done a fortnight later, after CBI took over the case—was considered too little too late, and Bhattacharya's statement that he had decided on it weeks earlier only evoked derision and did little to clean up his image. Now, West Bengal, considered too troubled a state to invest in, finds fewer and fewer takers.

In his youth, the chief minister used to translate the works of authors like Gabriel Garcia Marquez and Vladimir Mayakovsky. Now at 63, he shows great fondness for industrialists in whose company he spends many evenings. Since May last year, when he began his

third tenure as chief minister, he has attended at least 12 meetings of CII and many events of FICCI and the Indian Chamber of Commerce. Searching for solutions to retail in agricultural products or the creation of SEZs has become routine for him. Most sections of CPI(M) and the Left Front have been opposing

"The CM's idea of investment is only shopping malls and restaurant chains."

**PRADIPT BHATTACHARYA,
WORKING PRESIDENT, WBPCC**

the very same economic policies the implementation of which seems important for Bhattacharya. Seeking public investment and building consensus on public policies is normal for any chief minister. Except that in Bhattacharya's case, his position has always been at odds with the party bosses at the Centre, not to mention his own allies in the state. "We had committed serious mistakes in the sixties and seventies. The word *gherao* is our contribution to the Oxford dictionary," Bhattacharya had said earlier. His engagements with trade unions and other Front organisations have substantially decreased in the last 12 months but Marxist trade union CITU's Kolkata office has no complaints. "There is no fight with the chief minister on the issue of industrialisation in Bengal," says Shyamal Chakraborty, CITU's president (West Bengal). The so-called new-age Marxist has converted some in his state but Left leaders in Delhi disagree.

A CPI leader at Ajoy Bhawan in Delhi calls him "Gorbachev Bhattacharjee", referring to the chief minister's eagerness to reform Communist thinking in India, in much the same way that the former Soviet leader did in the late 1980s. Some in the country's Red establishment hold former Soviet president Michael Gorbachev's political reforms responsible for the disintegration of the Soviet Union. Bhattacharya is a member of the CPI(M) Politburo, which, after all, is not known for the elasticity of its thoughts. It is not surprising then that there are leaders in CPI(M) who firmly believe that if Bhattacharya were to stay on for much longer, he would manage to do to the West Bengal CPI(M) what Gorbachev had done to the Communist party of the Soviet Union. Last month, while CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat led a Left campaign against the joint exercises in the Bay of Bengal by the navies of five nations, including those of India and the US, the chief minister sat in his office reading proposals from US companies FreightCar America and the GE Group. The firms wished to set up their units in the state and Bhattacharya promised to do the needful.

While Karat and his counterparts in other Left parties squeezed the UPA Government into compromising on the Indo-US nuclear agreement,